tion with the work of his contemporary Akbar Padamsee, and a series of nameless miniatures, 'Untitled 1959-62', that express the young artist's restless but meticulous experimentation with varied influences, including that of his sometime comrade F.N. Souza.

Stepping out of the stillness of the Magazzini del Sale show into the bright sunshine and hubbub of Venice, its dazzling accumulation of mercantile-imperial history and all the razzmatazz of the Biennale, one is also confronted by the paradoxes of Husain's relationship with the global art-industrial complex. "The Guggenheim won't be rushing to do a Husain show...Well, I say, f*** 'em!" That's an outburst from the sculptor Anish Kapoor, himself an insider of the western art establishment, speaking in the recent documentary on the Indian modernist scene, *Kekee Manzil*. Kapoor was expressing his irritation at western curators being sniffy about Husain as a seemingly derivative painter, without grasping his engagement with a wealth of Indian motifs. He has a point, of course. Yet Husain remains a beguilingly ambiguous figure: a subaltern artist from the margins who embraced the privileges of wealth and fame and proximity to power. "He was candid, saying he was a 'court painter'," says the Mumbai gallerist Dadiba Pundole, an old friend of the artist. "He liked working for important patrons."

The posthumous patronage extended by the KNMA, in staging this show on the fringes of such a prestigious event, may also express some complex political and cultural messaging. On the one hand, given Husain's status as an icon of Nehru-Indira-era modernism, and as something of an artistic martyr, a victim of majoritarian intolerance, the show could be seen as a daring move. All the more so in a year when India has no 'official' presence at the Venice Biennale, while the KNMA was the driving force—and the main financier—of the last, Mahatma Gandhi-themed, national pavilion at the 2019 biennale. Indeed, there have been few exhibitions focused on Husain's work mounted by Indian galleries in recent years. Meanwhile, on a brief walk-through of the show, the curator Karode portrayed the late artist in terms that might well appeal to aggrieved nationalists. "The colonials took away our confidence, but Husain took us back to pre-modern times," she said, repeatedly praising his "civilisational" ethos. Could the Venice exhibition, and its accessible immersive, signal a new phase in the reputation of India's most famous artist? A posthumous homecoming in Modi's India? Certainly, the KNMA's grand plan for a new centre in Delhi promises to be a flagship in the new flotilla of public art institutions being set up by India's wealthiest art patrons, and Husain's berth here seems secure. The Nadar collection already includes at least 150 works by him. Not long ago, the Ambani heir, Anant, publicly received the gift of a Husain Ganesh rendered in the wood of a Dragon tree from the storied island of Socotra. At Abhishek Poddar's Museum of Art and Photography in Bengaluru, you can even speak to a Husain hologram. Yes, AI knows about Husain too. Try asking Google's Gemini LLM what the total worth of his lifetime's output of art is, and it will coyly demur for a while, feigning digital surprise at this crass question. But in the end, it will of course hazard a number. A very serious number. ■



SHOW TIME Husain painting live at the Sridharani Gallery, Delhi, 1968



"THE COLONIALS TOOK AWAY OUR CONFIDENCE, BUT HUSAIN TOOK US BACK TO PRE-MODERN TIMES. HE WAS THINKING CIVILISATIONALLY"

ROOBINA KARODE
Director and Chief Curator, Kiran Nadar Museum of Art